



TI De-escalation: Finding Your Intervention Superpower

Key Strategies & Takeaways
Trauma Informed Oregon • Portland State University

Not everyone de-escalates the same way, and that is a strength. Your superpower is the role that feels most natural to you in a moment of tension. Knowing your superpower means you can act with more confidence and less hesitation. You do not need all of them. You need the ones that fit you.

1 The 5Ds of Bystander Intervention

Direct - Speak up when it is safe. Address the situation clearly and steadily.

Distract - Interrupt the moment to shift attention. Ask for directions, drop something, start a conversation.

Delegate - Get help or involve others. Call someone with more capacity or authority.

Delay - Check in after the moment passes. Delayed support still matters.

Document - Record safely when needed. Prioritize the safety and consent of the person being targeted.

Synthesized from Right to Be (formerly Hollaback!). These five strategies provide a starting framework for anyone who wants to help.

2 Additional Practical Superpowers

Escort - Walk someone away from danger or stay with them. Your presence provides safety.

Buffer - Create physical space between people. Use your body as a steady barrier.

Exit Planner - Identify exits and help people leave quickly. Know the layout.

Resource Connector - Know who to call: 988, Portland Street Response, crisis lines, mutual aid.

Redirector - Shift attention away from the person being targeted. Break eye contact.

Steady Anchor - Stay regulated so others can settle. Offer food, water, or basic needs.

Narrator - Use steady language to slow escalation. Describe what is happening neutrally.

These roles are synthesized from bystander intervention, trauma-informed care, community safety, and dignity-centered practices.

3 Finding YOUR Superpower

- Which role feels most natural when you picture yourself in a tense situation?
- Which have you already done, even without knowing the name for it?
- Which ones feel uncomfortable? (That is useful information, not a flaw.)
- Can you think of a time when one of these would have helped?

Circle or highlight the 2-3 roles that feel most natural to you. There is no wrong answer.

4 When to Use Your Superpower (and When NOT To)

Ask yourself first - Am I safe enough? Is anyone armed or violent? Am I alone or do I have backup? Will this help or make it worse? What is my exit if this changes?

Use it when - You feel relatively safe. There is an exit route. Others are nearby. It feels manageable. Your gut says yes.

Step back when - Weapons are involved. You are alone or isolated. You are already activated. Violence has started. Your gut says no.

Not acting is still an action. You can switch strategies mid-situation. This is collective work. No one does it alone.

5 The Self-Check Questions

- What do I know? (facts vs. assumptions)
- What do I not know? (gaps, unknowns)
- What can I do? (within my capacity and role)
- What can I not do? (limits, boundaries, not mine to carry)

Use these in the moment and in debriefs. They become automatic with practice.